

DECISIVE MOMENT October 7, 1571 morning

# Battle of Lepanto

**The largest battle fought by galley fleets in the Mediterranean, the Battle of Lepanto was a clash between the Ottoman Turks and the Holy League of Spain, the Papacy, Venice, and Genoa. The aim of the Europeans was to save the island of Cyprus from the westward advance of the Ottomans, who already occupied most of Hungary and threatened Vienna and the Austrian lands. The result was a huge defeat for the Ottoman forces.**

The Ottomans, from northwestern Turkey (see pp.246–47), had taken territory from the Byzantine Empire (see pp.198–99). In 1453 they conquered the empire’s capital Constantinople (modern Istanbul), and in the next few years they took over most of its lands, from Serbia and Bosnia in the west to Anatolia in the east. By the early 16th century they were expanding again, destroying the power of Hungary at the Battle of Mohacs in 1526, and laying siege to Vienna in 1529—although they had to pull back from the city when they ran out of supplies and winter came.

In 1570, the Ottomans invaded the island of Cyprus. By moving into the Mediterranean, they threatened the freedom of wealthy cities such as Genoa and Venice to continue to travel and trade freely in the region (see pp.208–09). The Habsburg rulers of the Holy Roman Empire (see pp.188–89) were concerned they would be attacked again, and the Catholic Church also felt threatened by the Muslim Ottomans. As a result, Venice, Genoa, Spain (ruled by Philip II), and the Papacy formed an alliance, called the Holy League, in order to defend the

Mediterranean against the Ottomans. The League assembled a huge fleet of some 210 ships commanded by Don John of Austria, illegitimate son of the Habsburg emperor, Charles V. In 1571, Don John spotted the Turkish fleet, rather bigger than his own, off Lepanto (now Navpatkos), on the western coast of Greece. Both fleets were made up mainly of galleys, large warships powered by oarsmen. Don John also had six galleasses, powerful hybrid vessels with sails as well as oars, and with heavy cannons mounted along their flanks.

The ships of the League attacked quickly. The Turks preferred to fight by ramming their enemy’s ships, but Don John deployed the formidable firepower he carried. The tactics were a resounding success. The Ottoman commander, Ali Pasha, was killed, as were thousands of his men.

The Holy League destroyed the Turkish navy, but they did not destroy the Turks. The Ottomans built a new fleet, which was afloat within a year. The Turks kept control of Cyprus and the rest of their empire. But they did not expand farther westward, as they might have done if they had won.

## Don John of Austria goes to war

This painting by 16th-century Italian artist Andrea Micheli depicts the Battle of Lepanto, which was the last battle fought by galleys. The Holy League sank or captured around 200 of the Ottoman ships, losing only 15 of their own.



**“Strong gongs groaning as the guns boom far...”**

G. K. CHESTERTON, BRITISH AUTHOR, FROM THE POEM *LEPANTO*, 1915